

Reflection

For this project, my initial plan was to investigate some of the Washington State official databases for anything regarding political lobbying, compensation, and/or campaigning information to figure out where exactly money is going and who/what is putting who in power. Given the upcoming midterm elections and the general state of the world, recently, I found myself drawn to this topic, at least at a more state and local level as that is where I already have prior context as well as stake. Really, I was looking for what PACs were pumping the most money and more particularly, which political candidates were taking the most funding.

Initially, the database I found was regarding lobbying (Lobbyist Compensation and Expenses by Source), which I figured I could use to find the insights I was hoping for. Unfortunately, it more so gave information regarding the lobbyists themselves and their employers, not where the money was going or other relevant information. Thus, I instead landed on a database called, "Contributions to Candidates and Political Committees", which gave significantly more information on not just how much money was going where, but who it was coming and going to. Ultimately, the dataset was incredibly massive and required significant filtering and parsing, which made the task difficult. Also, much of the data was jumbled, with money going to both supporting/fighting bills and general candidates/PACs were mixed, which made deciphering where money was going to more difficult.

If I were to conduct this project again, I would have done a better job at filtering out ballot information and focusing purely on candidate support. I think that would have made the data much cleaner on top of easier to analyze. I think something else I could have done differently is focus purely on my hometown, Bellevue, rather than the entirety of Washington State. While these broader insights are interesting and do give perspective on just how much

control PACs have within the state, I think insights could have become more granular and specific had I pushed the magnifying glass on Bellevue alone. It would have been more relevant to me, as well.